

Example State University -- AI practice assessment (FICTIONAL)

FICTIONAL CONTENT. Example State University is an invented organization. No finding, citation, locator or figure here describes the University of Iowa or any real institution, system or person.

Executive summary

This report describes a fictional assessment of AI practice at Example State University. Every finding, citation, locator and figure below is invented for the purpose of exercising the printed output of the report template, and none of it describes any real institution. The assessment covered five areas across five operating units over a nine-week window. Of twenty-two assessed items, eight produced a supported finding, five produced a partial finding where the available evidence was consistent but incomplete, three produced a gap where an assessor looked and the practice was absent, and six remain unassessed because the fieldwork window closed before the relevant records could be opened. Unassessed items are reported as unassessed throughout and are excluded from every count of strengths and gaps; they are not scored, defaulted, or rolled into a proportion. Table 1 lists all twenty-two items and its dispositions sum to these figures.

The strongest single observation is that controls which are enforced by configuration survive staff turnover and controls which are enforced by convention do not. The clearest gap is that prompt and response logs generated by three applications carry no data classification and no retention setting, a condition that two separate active policies already address and neither of which is being executed against that log stream. The most consequential open question is whether prompt text submitted to an external vendor falls inside the institutional definition of institutional data; both readings are defensible from the policy text as written, and the answer changes the disposition of four items.

Finding F-001 -- configuration-enforced review survives turnover

Across fourteen sampled changes in the sampled repository, every merge to the protected branch required a named human reviewer, enforced by a required status check rather than by team convention. The distinction matters more than it appears to. A convention is carried by the people who remember it, and the assessment observed two units where an equivalent convention had quietly stopped being followed after a role change, without anyone noticing and without any record being produced. A required check produces a record when it is removed. The unit that enforces review in configuration can therefore demonstrate what happened; the units that enforce it by convention can only describe what they believe happens.

The limitation on this finding is that it establishes the presence of a gate, not the quality of the review passing through it. Fourteen changes is a sample, the sample was drawn from a single repository, and no attempt was made to assess whether the named reviewers read the changes carefully. A gate that everyone approves without reading is still a gate, and this assessment cannot distinguish the two cases from the records available to it.

Source: FICTIONAL. Branch protection configuration export, repository example-state/web-portal, retrieved 2026-08-29; rule set 'protect-main', required check 'sdhc/named-reviewer', required approving review count 1. Locator: export-2026-08-29T14:02Z.json, object path \$.rules[2].required_status_checks.contexts[0] -- see appendix A.3 for the full export. Corroboration: FICTIONAL. Pull requests #4412, #4418, #4423, #4431, #4437, #4440, #4444, #4451, #4455, #4460, #4463, #4468, #4470, #4475, sampled 2026-08-03 through 2026-08-28.

Finding F-002 -- AI prompt and response logs are unclassified and unretained

Three applications write prompt text and model responses into the default application log store. The assessor examined the retention configuration for that store and found it set to indefinite. The assessor then requested the data classification assigned to the store and was told that none has been assigned and that no steward is recorded. Two separate active standards reach this condition. One requires a defined retention period for application logs; the other requires a classification and a named steward for institutional data. Neither is a draft and neither is ambiguous about whether it applies to an application log store.

The instinct on seeing a finding of this shape is to write a new policy. A new policy would not have changed this condition, because two existing policies already say the right thing. What is missing is execution against a log stream that did not exist when either policy was written. The corrective action indicated by the evidence is an assignment of ownership for that stream, not a further statement of principle.

Source: FICTIONAL. Log retention configuration review, 2026-08-21, covering applications ESU-PORTAL, ESU-ADVISE and ESU-TICKET; retention field value 'indefinite' in all three. Locator: retention-review-2026-08-21.csv rows 4, 9, 17.
Source: FICTIONAL. Data classification register query, 2026-08-21, returned no record for log store 'app-log-default'. Locator: classification-register-export-2026-08-21.csv, searched on store_idenfier -- zero matching rows returned.

Finding F-003 - interview assertion is not corroborated by any record

Service desk staff state that an AI-generated ticket summary is always read against the original thread before the ticket is routed. The assessor has no reason to doubt the statement and no way to confirm it. The ticketing system records the routing decision and the time it was made; it does not record whether the summary or the thread was the basis for it. An assertion of this kind is recorded here as an assertion and is counted as neither a strength nor a gap, because promoting it to implementation evidence would mean reporting a belief as an observation.

The practical consequence is narrow and worth stating plainly. If the University wishes this practice to be demonstrable rather than merely stated, the change required is to the ticketing record, not to the practice. One additional captured field would move this item from an assertion to a directly inspectable artifact, and that is a smaller piece of work than it appears.

Source: FICTIONAL. Interview with the Service Desk Lead and two service desk analysts, 2026-08-14, notes filed as interview-2026-08-14-servicedesk.md in the engagement record. Corroboration attempted: FICTIONAL. Ticketing system field inventory retrieved 2026-08-18; locator ticket-schema-export-2026-08-18.json, object path \$.fields[*].name searched for any field capturing review of an AI-generated summary - zero matching fields returned. Note: the absence of a field is not evidence that the practice does not happen. It is evidence that the practice cannot be demonstrated from the record, which is a different statement.

Assessed items by area and disposition

The table below is deliberately wider than the text column. It is included because a table of this shape is what actually breaks a printed report: the natural width of the content exceeds the printable area, and a renderer that does not account for that will either run the last column off the edge of the paper or silently drop it.

Table 1 -- Assessed items by area and disposition (FICTIONAL)

Item identifier	Assessment area	Operating unit	Dispositio n	Evidence strength	Op
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ITM-001	Change review	Enterprise Applications	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	-
ITM-002	Data handling	Procurement	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	Q-
ITM-003	Vendor review	Student Systems	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	Q-
ITM-004	Log handling	Platform Engineering	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	Q-
ITM-005	Model change	Research Computing	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	Q-
ITM-006	Change review	Enterprise Applications	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	-
ITM-007	Data handling	Procurement	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	Q-
ITM-008	Vendor review	Student Systems	Supported	Direct - artifact inspected	Q-
ITM-009	Log handling	Platform Engineering	Partial	Indirect - related artifact only	Q-
ITM-010	Model change	Research Computing	Partial	Indirect - related artifact only	Q-
ITM-011	Change review	Enterprise Applications	Partial	Indirect - related artifact only	-
ITM-012	Data handling	Procurement	Partial	Indirect - related artifact only	Q-
ITM-013	Vendor review	Student Systems	Partial	Indirect - related artifact only	Q-
ITM-014	Log handling	Platform Engineering	Gap	Direct - looked, absent	Q-
ITM-015	Model change	Research Computing	Gap	Direct - looked, absent	Q-
ITM-016	Change review	Enterprise Applications	Gap	Direct - looked, absent	-
ITM-017	Data handling	Procurement	Unassessed	None gathered	Q-
ITM-018	Vendor review	Student Systems	Unassessed	None gathered	Q-
ITM-019	Log handling	Platform Engineering	Unassessed	None gathered	Q-
ITM-020	Model change	Research Computing	Unassessed	None gathered	Q-
ITM-021	Change review	Enterprise Applications	Unassessed	None gathered	-
ITM-022	Data handling	Procurement	Unassessed	None gathered	Q-

Phase 1 -- first ninety days

Assign ownership for the AI prompt and response log stream

The finding at F-002 is an ownership gap rather than a policy gap. The action indicated by the evidence is to name a steward for the log store and to apply one of the two retention schedules already in force. This is the only item in the roadmap whose prerequisite is a decision rather than work.

Answer the institutional-data scope question

Four assessed items are blocked on whether prompt text submitted to an external vendor is institutional data. Until that question has an answer, the disposition of those items cannot honestly be set, and any remediation designed against a guess may be designed against the wrong reading.

Phase 2 -- ninety to one hundred and eighty days

Extend configuration-enforced review beyond the one unit that has it

Finding F-001 established that a configuration-enforced gate produces a record when it is removed and a convention does not. Extending the enforced gate to the units currently relying on convention is the action with the clearest evidentiary support in this report.

Close the six unassessed items

Six items remain unassessed because the fieldwork window closed. They are not gaps and they are not passes. Closing them is ordinary remaining work and should not be confused with remediation.

Phase 3 -- beyond one hundred and eighty days

Give the model-change watch practice a named owner

The practice observed at ITM-009 is real, documented and repeated, and it exists because two engineers decided it should. It has no policy behind it and no role accountable for it. The risk is continuity, not compliance, and the action is an assignment rather than a control.